

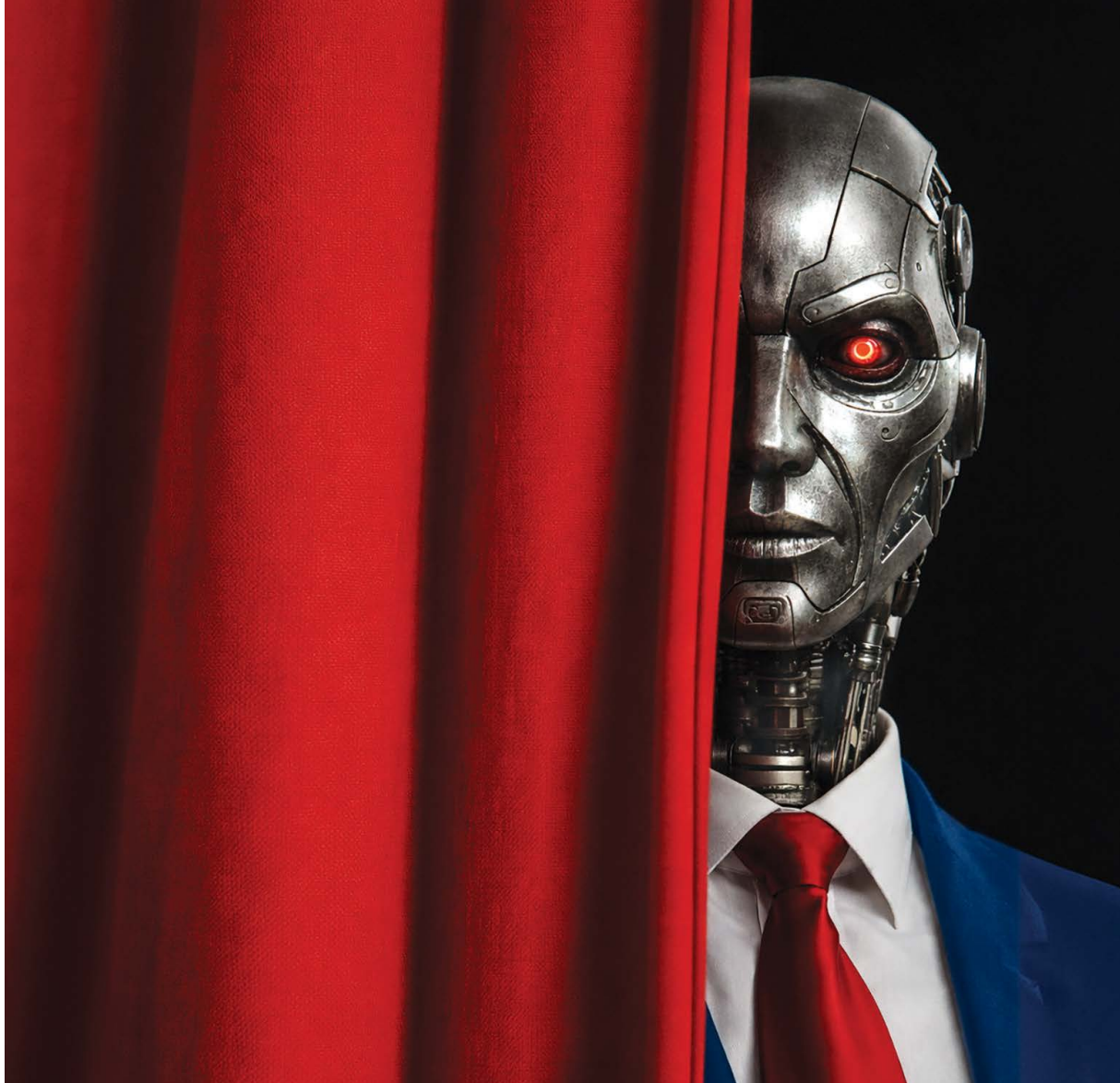


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INDIA'S AI MOMENT

This shift in work, jobs, businesses across sectors is unfolding as the country prepares for a high-profile showcase AI summit in mid-February: the India AI Impact Summit, where India is likely to push for a consensus on AI standards.

India has the second-largest user base for OpenAI's ChatGPT and considerable users of Grok AI, Google Gemini, and Perplexity, but has lagged the US and China in building foundational AI models. On whether India should have its own models or chart a different course, L&T's Ganesan says, "India may rely on imported high-end chips for now, but it can compete in solutions—building proprietary, domain-specific models and applications, especially where India's data and multilingual complexity create unique needs."

Carl Benedikt Frey, Dieter Schwarz Associate Professor of AI & Work at the Oxford Internet Institute,

told *BT* at the WEF that India should not "bet everything on large language models (LLMs)" and instead "embrace the open source," warning that it remains unclear whether today's dominant AI approach will prove to be the long-term winner.

Frey recommended the adoption of open-source models in business process contexts where India already has a lead. He also suggested doubling down on diverse research, including small language models and symbolic AI, while the market is still open. "If India takes its own course and makes the right bets, it could actually end up being a leader in AI," he said.

According to the NITI Aayog, AI could contribute 8-10% to India's GDP by 2035. But at present, India lacks a globally dominant foundational model like ChatGPT or Gemini in the US, or DeepSeek and ERNIE in China. India's AI compute muscle—roughly 38,000 graphic processing units (GPUs or chips used for AI workloads)—is